EVOLUTION OF THEATRE

The Modern Stage: Picture Frame to Black Box

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

How the stage changed from gaslight to LED: realism and the fourth wall, the director, the avant-garde, the black box and the festival stage.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- gaslight and the picture frame
- realism
- the director
- the avant-garde
- the black box

This is ZikShare's own teaching text, not a published book. It was written for this library and is free to read, print and use in class. The works listed at the end are the books to read next; they are not reproduced here and are not hosted by ZikShare.

The picture frame and the dark

The modern theatre begins with a change in the auditorium: the audience was put in the dark. Gas lighting, then electricity, allowed the house to be dimmed and the stage to be lit from the front, and the proscenium became a picture frame rather than a platform. The actor no longer played to a visible crowd; the actor played as if nobody were there.

That convention - the fourth wall - is the basis of realistic acting and of the director's theatre. It is a convention, not nature, and every revolt against realism has begun by breaking it.

Realism and the director

Ibsen, Strindberg, Chekhov and their companies made plays about ordinary people in ordinary rooms, and the box set - three walls, a ceiling, real furniture - was invented to hold them. The Duke of Saxe-Meiningen's company and André Antoine's Théâtre Libre established the director as the person who composed the stage picture and controlled the ensemble.

Stanislavsky's system came out of this work: if the audience is invisible and the room is real, the actor must supply an inner life that can be believed at three metres.

The revolts

Symbolism, expressionism, futurism, dada and surrealism attacked realism from the 1890s onwards: the stage became a dream, a machine, a manifesto. After the Second World War, Artaud's theatre of cruelty, Brecht's epic theatre, Beckett's absurd, Grotowski's poor theatre, Boal's theatre of the oppressed and Brook's empty space each proposed a different relationship between performer and audience.

What they share is a refusal of the invisible audience. They put the spectator back in the room.

The black box and the festival

The flexible black box - a plain room with a grid, black walls and movable seating - is the dominant theatre building of the last fifty years, because it can be rearranged for each production. It is cheap, and it makes the director responsible for the space as well as the staging.

Alongside it, the festival has become the main circuit for new work: Edinburgh, Avignon, Lagos Theatre Festival, the National Festival of Arts and Culture. Festivals reward the portable, the short and the surprising, and they have changed the shape of the plays written for them.

The director's theatre and the actor's theatre

Two traditions run through the modern stage and they disagree about where the meaning is made. In the director's theatre, the production is a composition: the text is material, the stage picture is the argument, and the director is the author of the evening. In the actor's theatre, the performance is the meaning: the text is a score, the actor is the instrument, and the director is a coach.

The twentieth century oscillated between them. The Meiningen company and Craig, Appia and Reinhardt built the director's theatre; the Moscow Art Theatre and the Actors Studio built the actor's. Brecht wanted both and wrote for a theatre where the staging argues with the acting.

Ask of any production you study: who is authoring the meaning? The answer tells you which tradition it belongs to, and it usually tells you what the production is worth.

The Nigerian modern

The modern stage did not arrive in Nigeria as a copy of Europe. It arrived through the church, the school, the travelling theatre and the university, and it produced its own modernism: Soyinka's total theatre, Rotimi's Yoruba tragedy, Osofisan's political musical, the festival play.

Place a Nigerian play beside a European one of the same decade and the conversation is more interesting than either alone: both are asking what a stage is for after the war, after independence, after the cinema took the popular audience.

Exercises

1. Compare the audience-performer relationship in a proscenium, a thrust and a black box, using the same scene.
2. Explain how electric lighting made the fourth wall possible, and what Brecht did with lighting to break it.
3. Take a realistic scene and restage it in an expressionist manner; list what had to change.

Where to read more

Oscar Brockett, History of the Theatre (any edition)

Peter Brook, The Empty Space (1968)

Marvin Carlson, Theories of the Theatre (1993)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.